

ZIMBABWE

FEBRUARY 2015 – JULY 2026

Prepared by Africa INSIGHTS Research Team | Vertical: Travel & Tourism

Zimbabwe's perception has risen 24 points since 2015, but a post-2022 retreat and worsening hospitality signal the destination needs to act now to protect its gains.

1,186

RECORDS IN VIEW

68%

POSITIVE

14%

NEUTRAL

18%

NEGATIVE

68/100

PERCEPTION

01 MONTH IN REVIEW

Zimbabwe's travel perception ends the reporting period in a materially stronger position than it entered — a **24-point improvement** from a perception score of **42 in 2015** to **66 in 2026** — but the headline disguises a deterioration that demands attention. After peaking at **78 in 2022**, scores have retreated across three consecutive years, and the negative share of sentiment has climbed back from **7.7%** at that peak to **19.9%** in 2026. Scenery remains an almost unassailable asset, but hospitality — the most-mentioned experiential theme after scenery — is worsening, and that slide is the single most actionable finding in this report.

The primary driver of positive perception is the physical landscape: scenery accounts for **356 mentions** with a net sentiment of **81.7**, and the emotional signature of the dataset reflects this, with excitement the dominant recorded emotion at **33.9%** of coded records. The drag on overall scores comes from the human and service layer — hospitality, safety, and, at indicative levels only, cost — where negative shares are elevated and, in hospitality's case, measurably worsening over the period.

The single thing to act on: the gap between Zimbabwe's world-class natural product and its service delivery is widening. A scenery-led campaign that does not address what visitors find when they arrive will continue to attract interest but fail to convert it into advocacy. The tourism board should prioritise a hospitality quality programme targeting frontline operators, and brief the creative team to move messaging beyond landscape photography toward evidence of the human welcome.

DATA NOTE

The report period runs from February 2015 to July 2026; year-level granularity means the 2026 data point covers only the first seven months of that year and should not be treated as a full-year figure.

DATA NOTE

The dataset is drawn almost entirely from YouTube comments (99.9% of records), which reflects online video audiences rather than the full spectrum of visitor opinion. Figures should be interpreted in that context.

02 PERCEPTION OVERVIEW

Zimbabwe scores **68 out of 100** on the perception scale for the full period, sitting 18 points above the scale's neutral midpoint of 50. Net sentiment stands at **50.5**, meaning positive records outrun negative ones by that margin across the **1,186** records in the dataset. The positive/neutral/negative breakdown — **68.1% positive, 14.2% neutral, 17.6% negative** — tells a story of a destination that commands genuine enthusiasm but has not yet suppressed a meaningful minority of critical voices.

The 14.2% neutral share is worth reading carefully. A large neutral block often signals ambivalence rather than indifference: travellers who find the destination interesting enough to comment on but not compelling enough to praise or condemn. For Zimbabwe, this middle ground likely reflects people drawn by the country's profile who are uncertain about practical realities. Converting that ambivalent audience is a more tractable marketing task than reversing negative opinion, and the scale of the positive majority — more than two in three records — means Zimbabwe already has the credibility to make that case.

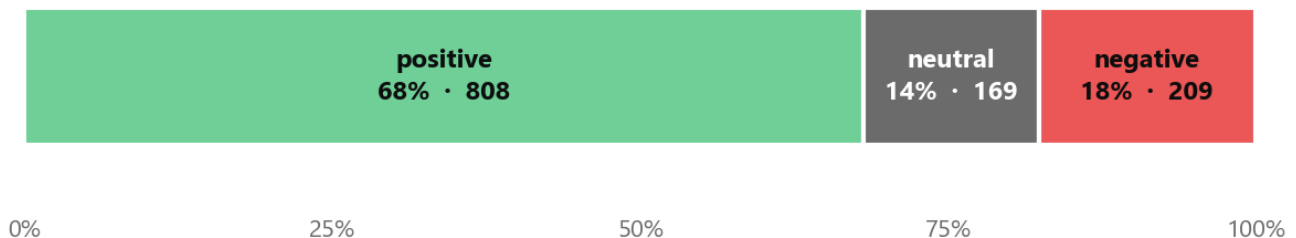
The **17.6% negative share** is not alarming in isolation, but combined with the post-2022 trend it is a warning light. In 2022, the negative share was **7.7%**; by 2026 it had risen to **19.9%**. The overall period score of 68 flatters the current position: the destination today is performing materially below where it was at its peak, and the direction of the negative share is upward. The perception score, in other words, is a weighted average of a very good recent past and a softening present.

DATA NOTE

Net sentiment of 50.5 and perception score of 68 are period aggregates; year-on-year movement discussed in Section 06 shows the current position is weaker than these aggregates suggest.

Figure 1 — Sentiment breakdown

How the 1,186 records in view split across sentiment classes. Net sentiment is +50 points.



03 THEMATIC ANALYSIS

Scenery is Zimbabwe's defining competitive asset and the engine of its positive perception. With **356 mentions** — the highest of any theme — and a net sentiment of **81.7**, it is both the most discussed and the most positively received aspect in the dataset. Only **8.1%** of scenery mentions are negative, an exceptionally low figure that reflects the near-universal appeal of Zimbabwe's physical landscape, anchored by Victoria Falls and the broader wilderness. Scenery's movement is **stable** across the period, which is reassuring: this is a durable, dependable asset that will not erode without a serious external shock. The marketing implication is not to invest more in communicating the scenery — awareness is already high — but to treat it as the door through which visitors walk before encountering the service themes that are underperforming.

Wildlife, with **60 mentions** and a net of **30.0**, is a positive contributor but carries a meaningful negative share of **28.3%**. The negative commentary on wildlife most likely reflects disappointment relative to expectation — visitors

arriving with safari benchmarks set by Kenya or Tanzania and finding encounters less reliable or less curated. Hospitality, the second-most-mentioned experiential theme at **128 mentions**, tells a more urgent story: its net sentiment of **23.4** is positive in direction but its negative share of **34.4%** is the highest of any reportable theme, and it is the only reportable theme confirmed to be worsening. As @Lsgworx (Jul 2022) noted, "Zimbabwe has the most hard working and intelligent people, also very kind" — but that warmth is not translating consistently into positive visitor experience, and the gap between reputation and delivery is growing.

Safety carries **23 mentions** and a net of **17.4**, which is technically positive but rests on a thin base and includes a **34.8%** negative share — the joint-highest among reportable themes alongside hospitality. While safety is not yet a dominant narrative, its negative share is material enough that a single high-profile incident or media cycle could shift it quickly. Transport, with **35 mentions** and a net of **48.6**, is a relative bright spot among experiential themes, though the voice of @photonfantastic (Aug 2024) — describing the "extent of the decay" on the Harare–Victoria Falls rail route — is a reminder that infrastructure satisfaction is uneven and that aggregate positivity may mask specific corridors of concern. Food registers a net of **38.9** across **18 mentions** but carries a **27.8%** negative share; it meets the reporting threshold but sits at the lower end of volume and should be watched rather than acted on urgently.

DATA NOTE

Five themes — water, weather, electricity, housing, and cost — fall below the 15-mention minimum and are excluded from headline findings. Their directional signals are discussed in Section 06 where the movement data are informative, but no findings are anchored to them.

DATA NOTE

The transport theme's positive aggregate net (48.6) co-exists with qualitative evidence of infrastructure decay; operators should not interpret the net score as blanket endorsement.

Voices behind the numbers

The most-engaged supportive and critical mentions in this view. Emoji and non-Latin characters are stripped for print.

POSITIVE · @johnajah4752 · Mar 2022 · 959 likes · score +0.82

"I am Nigerian and seriously looking forward to visiting Zimbabwe maybe with family or students on excursion one day.....Love your guys Zimbabweans"

POSITIVE · @Lsgworx · Jul 2022 · 846 likes · score +0.70

"Im South African and I can tell you that Zimbabwe has the most hard working and intelligent people, also very kind"

NEGATIVE · @realityDUBSTEP · Aug 2024 · 5,248 likes · score -0.85

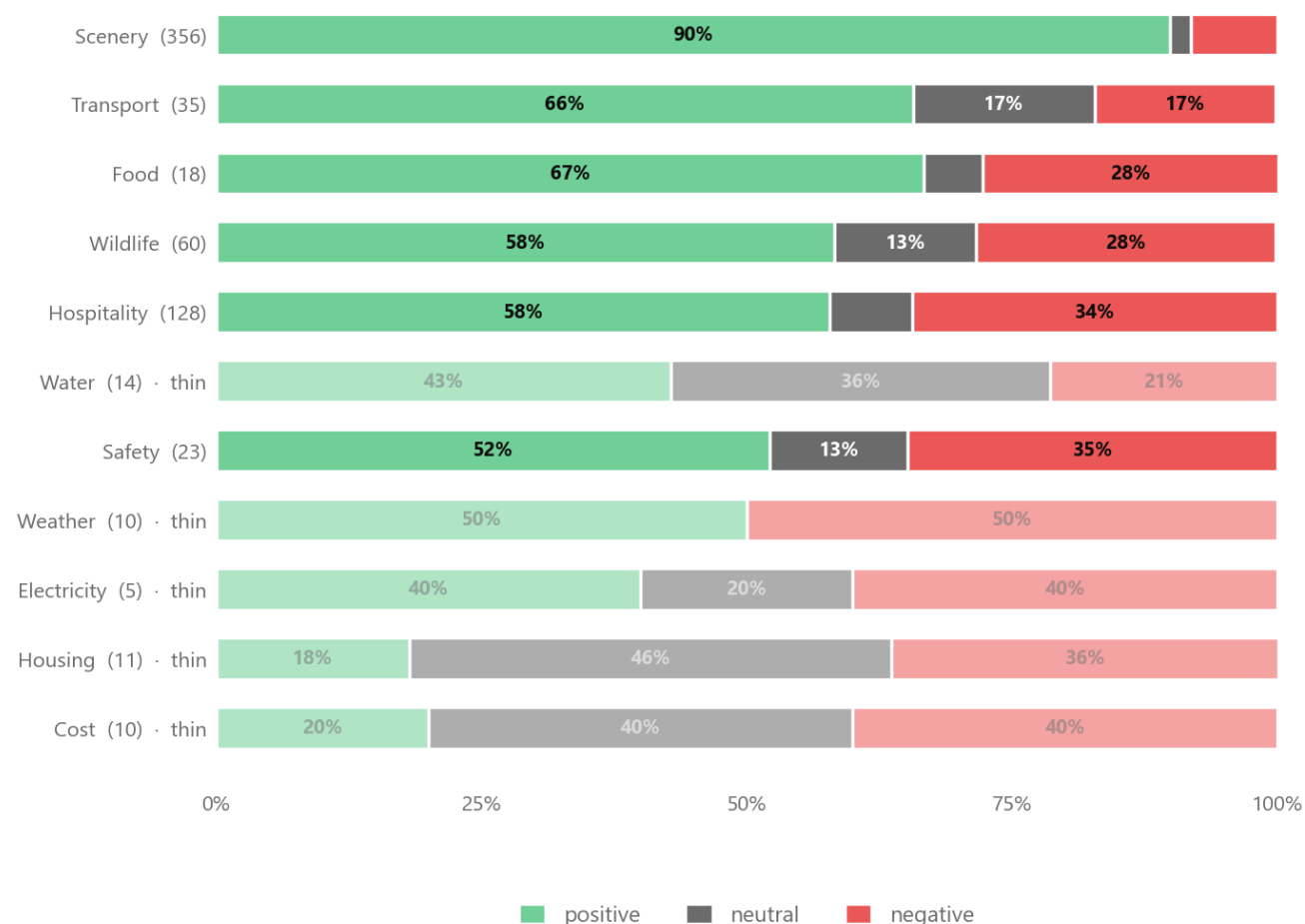
"How can poverty exist in Zimbabwe if everyone is a trillionaire?"

NEGATIVE · @groovedive1 · Aug 2024 · 3,299 likes · score -0.83

"I wonder if in 30 years someone as yourself will be visiting England and wondering why it has become a forgotten ghost town."

Figure 2 — Sentiment by theme

Every travel theme mentioned in this view, ranked by net sentiment. Mention counts in brackets; themes below the 15-mention floor are faded and marked thin.



04 VISITOR SEGMENTS

The segment classification covers only **7.5%** of the dataset, with **1,097** records unclassified. Of the four cohorts identified, only the adventure traveller segment clears the 50-record evidence threshold and can support reportable findings. Direct comparisons between cohorts are not possible under the evidence rules that govern this report, but the adventure cohort's profile is informative in its own right and points clearly toward where Zimbabwe's most engaged international audience sits.

Adventure travellers — **74 records**, representing **6.2%** of classified volume — give Zimbabwe a perception score of **65** and a net sentiment of **33.8**, with **60.8%** positive and **27.0%** negative records. That negative share is higher than the overall dataset average of **17.6%**, which reflects the nature of adventure travel: this segment engages more critically with practical realities — terrain, logistics, safety, infrastructure — and is less likely to be satisfied by scenery alone. The destination's strong physical product gives it a genuine claim on adventure audiences, but the elevated negative share suggests that the experience layer — how bookings are managed, how operators handle risk, how transport and guiding meet expectations — is not consistently matching the landscape promise. Adventure travellers are also influential multipliers: they tend to produce detailed, credible content that shapes decisions for others in their networks. Investing in the adventure product's quality and reliability would therefore have an outsized effect on organic advocacy.

The indicative signals from budget, business, and luxury cohorts — each with fewer than 50 records and therefore excluded from reportable findings — suggest that these segments have distinct profiles, but the data are not sufficient to draw conclusions or make targeting comparisons. The tourism board should treat the classification gap as a research priority: understanding how luxury and business travellers perceive Zimbabwe is strategically important, and the current dataset does not support that analysis.

DATA NOTE

Only one visitor cohort — adventure — clears the 50-record minimum threshold. Budget (6 records), business (6 records), and luxury (3 records) cohorts are indicative only and cannot headline findings or be compared against the adventure segment or each other.

DATA NOTE

Only 7.5% of records carry a segment classification, meaning the classified view may not represent the full visitor population. A richer segment-tagging methodology would significantly improve targeting insight in future periods.

VISITOR SEGMENT	RECORDS	SHARE OF VIEW	PERCEPTION	NET
Adventure	74	6.2%	65/100	+34
Budget · thin	6	0.5%	40/100	-33
Business · thin	6	0.5%	67/100	+50
Luxury · thin	3	0.3%	32/100	-33

05 COMPETITIVE BENCHMARKING

Zimbabwe ranks **6th out of 10** reportable peers in perception score, with a score of **68** against the group leader Tanzania at **73** — a gap of **5 points**. The mid-table position is not a crisis, but it is also not where a destination with Zimbabwe's natural endowment should settle. Ghana, Rwanda, and Senegal all score **70**, and Kenya scores **69**, meaning Zimbabwe sits in a cluster of well-regarded African destinations with a score that offers no meaningful differentiation. Zimbabwe does outperform the bottom tier — South Africa at **65**, Egypt at **64**, Nigeria at **62**, and Morocco at **39** — but a destination with the world's largest waterfall and an established safari reputation should be contesting the top of this table, not the upper-middle.

The positive dimension of Zimbabwe's competitive standing: its positive share of **68.1%** is competitive with Ghana (**68.5%**) and ahead of South Africa (**59.3%**), Egypt (**59.3%**), and Nigeria (**57.3%**). The negative share of **17.6%** is higher than Tanzania (**12.2%**), Rwanda (**15.3%**), and Kenya (**14.7%**), which is where the score gap is being lost. Closing that negative share to the levels achieved by the top three peers is the lever most likely to move Zimbabwe's overall ranking.

On transport, Zimbabwe holds a **49.7-point advantage** in net sentiment over the peer average — a striking lead that reflects well on the in-country movement experience relative to comparators. On safety, Zimbabwe also leads peers by **22.0 points** in net sentiment, a finding that runs counter to the narrative risk identified in the thematic section and should be actively communicated: Zimbabwe is, by the evidence in this dataset, perceived as meaningfully safer than the peer group average. These two advantages are underexploited in Zimbabwe's destination marketing relative to the more generic scenery-first messaging that dominates current positioning.

DATA NOTE

Cameroon (16 records) does not clear the 50-record minimum and is excluded from the reportable peer ranking. The stated rank of 6th out of 10 reflects the 9 reportable peers plus Zimbabwe.

DATA NOTE

The scenery and wildlife aspect gaps versus peers do not clear the 10-point reportable threshold and are not stated as competitive differentials in this section.

DATA NOTE

Peer comparisons are drawn from the same YouTube-dominant data source; any systematic differences in how audiences engage with different country content on that platform could influence relative scores.

MARKET	RECORDS	PERCEPTION	NET SENTIMENT
Tanzania	1,326	73/100	+59
Ghana	1,094	70/100	+52
Rwanda	1,526	70/100	+54
Senegal	1,114	70/100	+50
Kenya	2,075	69/100	+52
Zimbabwe	1,186	68/100	+50
South Africa	2,164	65/100	+39
Egypt	2,305	64/100	+36
Nigeria	1,884	62/100	+33
Morocco	52	39/100	-21

06 TRENDS & SIGNALS

The long-run trajectory is one of genuine recovery. Zimbabwe's perception score rose from **42 in 2015** to a peak of **78 in 2022**, a **36-point** ascent over seven years that reflects improved post-crisis confidence, growing international content interest, and the draw of the physical landscape cutting through. The negative share fell in parallel, from **50.0% in 2015** to just **7.7% in 2022**. That 2022 peak coincided with the period's highest concentration of engaged positive commentary and represents the strongest Zimbabwe perception on record in this dataset.

The signal that demands attention is the post-2022 retreat. Scores fell to **63 in 2019** before recovering, but the current decline from the 2022 peak feels different: negative share has risen in three consecutive measured periods — **9.3% in 2023**, **20.2% in 2024**, **16.9% in 2025**, and **19.9% in 2026** — and is now running at more than double its 2022 level. The **2026 figure covers only the first seven months of the year** and should be watched carefully as the full year data emerge. The 2024 and 2025 years carry the largest record volumes in the dataset — **89 and 272 records** respectively, with 2026 already at **256** — meaning the post-peak deterioration is well-evidenced and not a thin-sample artefact.

At the thematic level, the one confirmed signal within reportable bounds is **hospitality worsening**: its negative share rose across the two halves of the period, a movement of **6.5 points** that clears the trend threshold. All other worsening themes — transport, safety, food, weather, cost — do not clear the evidence threshold for their movement data and should be treated as indicative rather than confirmed signals. The one confirmed stable theme is scenery, which is a floor that the destination can rely on. The overall picture is of a destination whose natural-asset perception is holding but whose service-layer perception is under pressure and drifting in the wrong direction.

DATA NOTE

Movement data for transport, safety, food, weather, and cost do not meet the reportable threshold for trend findings; their directional signals are noted as indicative only.

DATA NOTE

The 2026 data point covers February–July 2026 only. Full-year comparability with prior years is not possible until the complete year's data are available.

DATA NOTE

Years 2015 and 2017 carry fewer than 50 records each (12 and 21 respectively), meaning year-level perception scores for those periods are based on thin samples and should be treated with caution.

Figure 3 — Perception over time (by year)

Perception score per period on a 0–100 scale, where 50 is neutral.

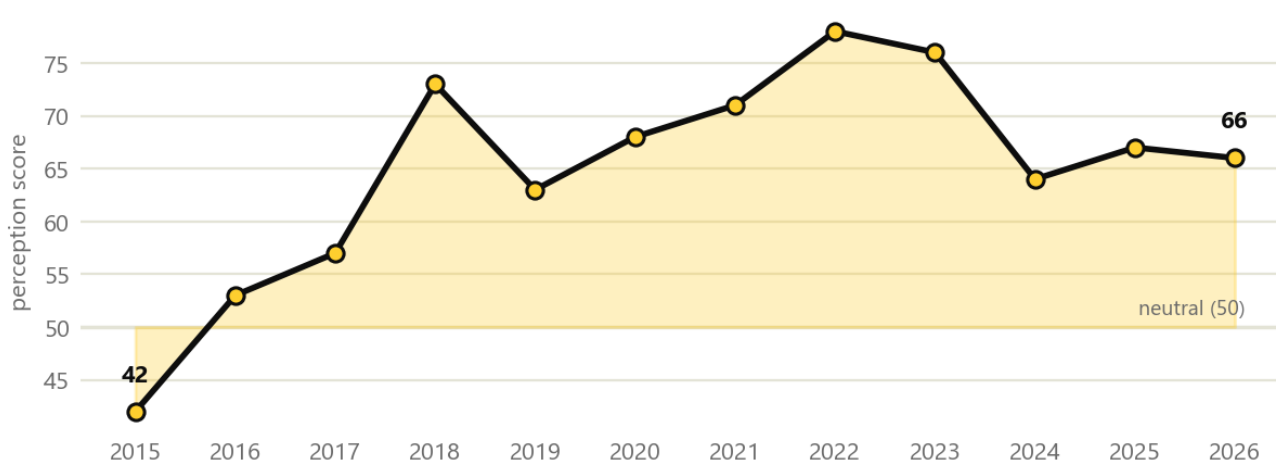
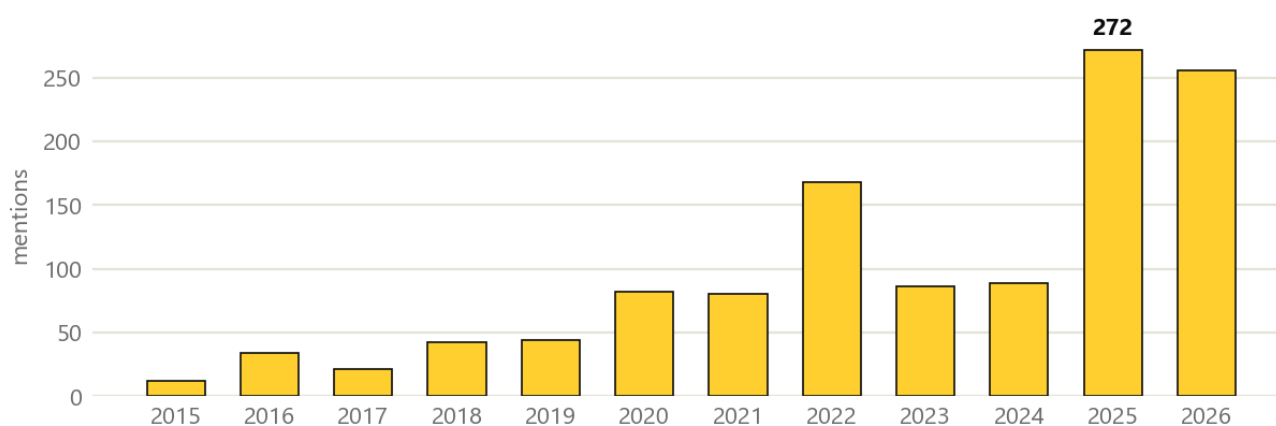


Figure 4 — Conversation volume (by year)

Records per period. Read the trend above against this: a swing on thin volume is noise.



07 RECOMMENDATIONS

The confirmed worsening of hospitality — the second-most-mentioned theme at **128 mentions** and now carrying a **34.4%** negative share that has grown across the period — requires a structured quality intervention, not a messaging fix. The Zimbabwe Tourism Authority should commission a frontline hospitality audit across the Victoria Falls corridor and Hwange lodges, the facilities most likely to be generating the online commentary in this dataset, and establish a measurable service standard that operators must meet to carry destination-endorsed branding. The target audience for this recommendation is mid-range lodge and camp operators, who sit between the premium segment (where standards tend to be self-reinforcing) and the budget end (where expectation is lower); this middle tier generates the highest volume of public-facing commentary and is most exposed to the gap between landscape promise and service delivery.

The **22.0-point lead over peers in safety net sentiment** and the **49.7-point lead in transport net sentiment** are genuine competitive advantages that Zimbabwe is not currently communicating. The destination marketing team should build a campaign module — distinct from the scenery-led flagship — that directly addresses the practical concerns that hold undecided travellers back. Targeted at the large neutral audience (14.2% of records) and at potential first-time visitors from Nigeria and South Africa — markets from which the most engaged positive voices in this dataset originate — this module should foreground ease of travel, in-country movement, and the safety record relative to regional alternatives. These are evidence-based claims the team can stand behind.

The adventure traveller segment is the only cohort with sufficient data to support targeting decisions, and its elevated negative share of **27.0%** against a perception score of **65** points to a product reliability gap rather than a marketing gap. The recommendation is to work with specialist adventure operators to improve pre-trip information, itinerary contingency, and guide quality — specifically on the activities and routes most associated with the wildlife and transport themes where expectations are highest. Adventure travellers are disproportionately influential content creators; improving their experience will produce advocacy that reaches audiences the marketing budget cannot buy. A post-trip feedback mechanism tied to these operators would also begin to close the segment-classification gap that currently prevents the research team from making comparisons across luxury, business, and budget cohorts.

DATA NOTE

Luxury, business, and budget segment recommendations cannot be made with specificity in this period because those cohorts do not meet the 50-record evidence threshold. Enriching segment classification in future data collection should be treated as a research priority.

DATA NOTE

The transport and safety peer-gap findings are drawn from thematic benchmarking; Zimbabwe's transport lead in particular should be interpreted alongside the qualitative evidence of infrastructure decay noted by @photonfantastic (Aug 2024), suggesting the aggregate advantage may be uneven across specific routes or modes.

08 METHODOLOGY & PROVENANCE

Country	Zimbabwe
Year range	2015–2026
Aspect (any of)	all aspects
Sentiment	positive, neutral, negative
Data source	all

Relevant records only	yes
Period	February 2015 – July 2026
Records	1,186
Generated	19 Aug 2026 12:39 UTC
Narrative	Written by claude-sonnet-4-6; every figure verified against the computed data.

Evidence base: 1,185 YouTube comments, 1 YouTube transcript segment. 90% of records were attributed to this market from what the text itself is about rather than from the query that surfaced them. Sentiment is scored by a multilingual transformer; themes, emotion and visitor segment are rule-based taggers. Evidence thresholds: 50 records for a reliable view, 15 mentions before a theme can headline a finding, 5 points before a theme counts as praised or criticised, 10 points before a cross-country gap is stated. Every figure in this report is computed from the filtered records by the analysis pipeline. The written analysis interprets those figures; each number it states is verified back against them before publication, and any section that fails verification is replaced by the deterministic summary.